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From the editor-in-chief

The night of November 26 last year changed India. The audacity of the attack where 10 well-trained youths crossed our marine borders undetected, entered our commercial capital and with meticulous planning, guided by their Pakistan-based handlers, wreaked havoc for 60 hours on live television. The world watched as India faltered, fumbled and blundered. Our handling of this attack left us naked before the world. Surely, there have been other terrorist attacks on India but none has exposed the weaknesses of our security systems and intelligence services in such a blatant manner. Right from the Coast Guard patrol to the local police and even the elite NSG. This was our 9/11. Look at what America did to secure their country after that attack. They created Fortress America. Sadly, in spite of our traumatic event we have done precious little. We remain Fungible India.

The events of Mumbai took place in two well-known luxury hotels, a 120-year-old railway terminus traversed by thousands every day, a popular cafe filled with foreign tourists and locals, an unknown place of refuge and a commonplace maternity hospital. Terrorists opened fire and cut down men and women of every social strata of the city and from every corner of the globe.

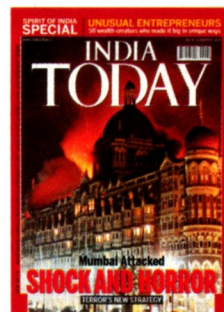
Twelve months after, Mumbai's stories still belong to two sides. On one side are the heroic deeds of hotel staff who saved guests, railway workers who managed to empty out a couple of platforms, NSG commandos who rescued and released hostages and the common people who helped each other during a great crisis. On the other side is the great shame of 26/11. It is now certain that a series of chilling events took place in India's most cosmopolitan and vibrant city because of the failure of those whose job it is to protect us.

Our cover story is a return to what were the nightmare hours of a nation. We have revisited the victims and their heroes, identified the mistakes made before those days and followed what happened to those who had failed at their jobs during that time. Knowing how Indian bureaucracy looks after itself, it is not surprising that those who let the people down have not only not been punished but kept their jobs. Believe it or not, Maharashtra's then Home Minister R.R. Patil is back in the saddle in the same position.

As part of INDIA TODAY's War on Terror campaign launched after 26/11, we have returned to the agenda we had listed 12 months ago and offer an assessment of what has been done and not done. Our internal security needed to be revamped, our local police overhauled in big cities, the money trail of terror groups cut off. Unfortunately, although we now have an active and competent home minister, little has happened institutionally to give us any comfort. The fact that no attack has taken place in the country after 26/11 is, I believe, by default rather than design.

India must never forget it is in the firing line of many well-equipped and liberally-funded militant groups across the border which are often supported by the armed services of our prickly neighbour. Saving the innocent lives of our citizens requires everyone's collective and focused effort. We need to build Fortress India. There is no other option.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR DECEMBER
2008 COVER